

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Wildfire smoke

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

For smoke without an immediate fire threat, stay indoors with windows and doors closed, use filtered recirculated air or a portable air cleaner, and check local air-quality updates. If ordered to evacuate, leave promptly. Severe breathing difficulty requires emergency medical help.

Do now.

- ☐ **Know which problem you face**
01 Check official fire, evacuation, and air-quality notices for your address. An evacuation order changes the decision immediately.
- ☐ **If leaving, leave early**
02 Take people, pets, medication, keys, and essentials; tell a contact where you are going. Use the evacuation guide and current route instructions.
- ☐ **If sheltering from smoke**
03 Close windows and doors. Set HVAC to recirculate where possible, use a portable air cleaner or a cleaner indoor room, and avoid adding indoor smoke from candles, frying, or smoking.
- ☐ **Limit outside exposure**
04 If you must go outside in smoke, a well-fitting N95 or P100 respirator can reduce particle exposure; ordinary cloth masks do not provide the same protection.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Create one cleaner-air room using safe filtration if available, reduce indoor smoke sources and avoid strenuous activity. Do not overheat a sealed home; move to a safer breathable and cooler place if you cannot maintain both air quality and safe temperature.

Watch for.

If fire threatens the building or officials order departure, indoor smoke control is no substitute for evacuation. If breathing becomes difficult or symptoms are severe, seek urgent medical help.

People & practical needs.

Check people with lung or heart disease, pregnancy-related needs and infants more often. Plan low-exposure activities and keep prescribed medicines accessible. A designated cleaner room must still be comfortable, reachable and usable for the people inside.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Keep checking changing wind, fire perimeter, and air-quality conditions. People with heart or lung disease, children, older adults, and pregnant people may need added precautions or clinical advice.

Questions in the field.

What if closing windows makes the home too hot?

Smoke reduction must be balanced with safe temperature. Check a cooler location with cleaner air and the ability to meet medical or access needs. Do not keep a vulnerable person in dangerous heat simply to preserve a closed room.

Can any mask filter smoke?

Loose face coverings do not provide the same particle protection as a well-fitting approved respirator. Particle respirators do not remove gases and may not fit children or everyone who needs one. Reduce exposure and seek medical guidance for breathing problems.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Wildfire · official guidance

<https://www.ready.gov/wildfires>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/wildfire-smoke/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.